Chapter 0

A Revolution Written in Red

In a world where everything had a price, she was determined to become the one thing no one could buy.

Centuries had passed since the age of magic.

The Elves had vanished from the world, and the Orcs had faded into the forgotten pages of history. Their kingdoms were gone, their voices silenced by time, leaving behind only fragments of an ancient civilization and the mysterious stones that had once powered their greatest creations.

Humanity had inherited their legacy.

What was once the exclusive power of the Elves had become the foundation of an entirely new age. Engineers learned to harness the energy within the stones, transforming them into the lifeblood of civilization. Steam-powered locomotives thundered across vast railway networks. Mechanical factories consumed entire districts with their smoke. Airships drifted between towering cities, their engines glowing with the blue light of refined energy crystals.

Humanity called it progress.

And the world had never been more unequal.

Above the clouds of industrial smoke stood magnificent cities of brass, iron, and glass, where wealthy families enjoyed warm homes, mechanical servants, and endless luxuries. Beneath them lay the slums, where exhausted workers spent their lives feeding the machines that kept the upper districts alive.

The government called this order.

The poor called it survival.

And those who dared to challenge it were called criminals.

In the Republic of Valtheris, the President ruled from a magnificent capital built upon the foundations of an ancient Elven settlement. Under his administration, the energy trade had become the exclusive privilege of the wealthy, laborers were worked to exhaustion, and entire communities were driven from their homes to make room for new factories and power stations.

The President promised prosperity.

His people received chains.

It was in this world that a young woman learned to steal.

She was no noblewoman, no revolutionary leader, and certainly no hero. She possessed no grand inheritance, no influential connections, and no remarkable talent beyond the ability to disappear when trouble arrived.

She was a thief.

A good one, too.

With a worn leather coat, a weathered longbow, and a collection of arrows she had modified herself, she survived by robbing merchant convoys, sabotaging wealthy collectors, and stealing anything valuable enough to keep her fed.

She preferred rooftops to streets, shadows to crowds, and the company of her own thoughts to the promises of powerful men.

Her arrows rarely missed.

Her patience was legendary.

And her trust in authority was nonexistent.

For years, she had watched the world devour the weak. She had seen children working in factories before they were old enough to read, families evicted because they could not pay their energy taxes, and workers beaten for demanding wages that had already been promised to them.

She had learned that the law was not a shield for the innocent.

It was a weapon held by those who could afford to wield it.

At first, she stole because she was hungry.

Then she stole because she wanted to survive.

Eventually, she began stealing because she could no longer stand the sight of those who had everything taking even more from those who had nothing.

But a handful of stolen coins could not feed an entire district. A few sabotaged machines could not bring down a government. And no matter how many wealthy merchants she robbed, the system that made them powerful remained untouched.

Something had to change.

Not tomorrow.

Not someday.

Now.

The idea began as a foolish thought, whispered to herself while watching another line of exhausted workers march through the streets beneath the watchful eyes of government soldiers.

What if we stopped running?

What if the thieves, smugglers, mercenaries, smugglers' captains, disgraced soldiers, and outcasts of the world stopped fighting merely to survive? What if they turned their weapons toward the people who had built a kingdom upon their suffering?

What if the criminals of Valtheris became the ones who brought its rulers to justice?

It was a dangerous idea.

An impossible idea.

And perhaps the most foolish idea she had ever entertained.

But for the first time in her life, she had found something worth risking everything for.

She would gather the people the world had discarded. She would unite those who had every reason to hate the government and nothing left to lose. Together, they would strike at the foundations of the Republic, expose the corruption hidden beneath its polished brass walls, and overthrow the President who had mistaken the suffering of his people for the price of progress.

She had no army.

No fortune.

No promise of victory.

Only a bow, a handful of arrows, and a growing list of names belonging to people who might be willing to fight.

The government would call her a terrorist.

The newspapers would call her a menace.

The President would call her a problem to be eliminated.

But the people living beneath the smoke might one day call her something else.

A symbol.

A spark.

A revolution.

And so, beneath the shadow of the great industrial capital, a thief began searching for criminals.

Not to rob them.

Not to sell them out.

But to ask them a single question.

"How much longer are we going to let them own our lives?"

Her name would soon become a whisper in the alleys, a rumor aboard smuggler airships, and a warning passed between government officials who had never imagined that someone so insignificant could threaten everything they had built.

They would call her Rouge.

And this time, she was not planning an escape.

She was planning a revolution.